entry to high-profile events like the Olympic Games. Once the initial contact is made, the Chinese Embassy in New Delhi regularly reaches out to political figures to plug their narratives during key negotiations between India and China. The ILD has been able to function without constraints in many democracies worldwide, including in India, also because it has gained legitimacy by operating from the safety of Chinese diplomatic premises in world capitals.

An even lesser-known organization which plays an important role in shaping and influencing negotiations is the State Council Information Office (*Guowuyuan Xinwen Bangongchu* or SCIO). While its primary focus is to manage the Chinese domestic media, the SCIO also oversees the entirety of China's overseas publicity work through the External Propaganda Office (*Waixuanban*). Its objective is to tell China's preferred 'story' to the world on any particular issue. It manages the vast media apparatus that the People's Republic of China has built over the decades. At one end of the spectrum is the Xinhua (New China News Agency) which has correspondents in many world capitals and is a principal source for gathering information and even intelligence. Then there are the many Chinese newspapers and magazines, most prominently the *People's Daily*, through which messages are transmitted to the outside world on China's viewpoint in international affairs. The Chinese are well aware that the contents of the *People's Daily* are read by governments across the world as a window to the thinking in Chinese officialdom, and it is used with great effect in messaging on key foreign policy issues, including in the course of negotiations when its language can be carefully calibrated as per the escalation matrix. Then there are the English language dailies—the *China Daily* and its more incendiary cousin, the *Global Times*—which are wholly devoted to external propaganda.